



BEFORE

The origins of the world war lie in European rivalries stretching back more than 40 years.

TRIPLE ENTENTE

German unification in 1871, << 330–33 and its rise to military and industrial power, combined with its commercial and imperial ambitions in Europe, the Middle East, and Africa, alarmed its neighbors. The German defeat of France in 1871 had made the two countries bitter enemies. Germany constructed **defensive alliances** with

first Austria-Hungary and then Italy, while France looked to Russia and Britain. A naval **arms race** between Britain and Germany added to the growing military tension.

SCHLIEFFEN PLAN

Fearing war on two fronts, against France and

Russia, in 1905, the German chief of the general staff, General von Schlieffen, drew up a plan for Germany to deliver a **knockout blow against France**, before turning to face the huge, but slow-to-mobilize, Russian army.



RUSSIAN THREAT

The beginning of the twentieth century saw Europe divided into two armed camps. Germany had formed an alliance with Austria-Hungary in 1879 (see BEFORE) as it felt threatened by the hostile nations at its borders and needed to protect its interests in Central Europe and the Balkans. France, Russia, and later Britain formed their own alliance, in part to protect themselves against possible German aggression.

The road to war

The spark that caused the war was the assassination of Archduke Ferdinand, heir to the Austro-Hungarian throne, by a Serb fanatic in Sarajevo, capital of Austrian Bosnia (see pp. 370–71).

Austria accused Serbia of complicity in the murder, and gained German support. Austria refused a compromise with Serbia and, on July 28, declared war. Continental war was unavoidable as both sides honored commitments to their allies. Russia mobilized its troops in support of Serbia, and when German demands for it to stop were refused, Germany declared war on Russia on August 1. Knowing that France would support Russia, Germany then declared war on France on August 3 and implemented the Schlieffen Plan (see BEFORE) sending its army through Belgium in an attempt to knock France out of the war, before turning its attention on Russia. Britain initially held back, but honored its

guarantee of Belgian independence, agreed by treaty in 1839, and declared war against Germany on August 4.

Deadlock

The initial German advance was halted in early September, 50 miles (80 km) east of Paris, by a combined French and British army. Both sides then raced north toward the English Channel to try to break through around the side of their enemy's lines. When this failed, the two sides dug in along the length of the Western Front. Stalemate lasted there until almost the end of the war, as the defensive capabilities of the machine gun prevented any significant advance by either side. Allied attempts to break the deadlock at Neuve

The Great War

In July 1914 a war broke out in the Balkans that within days spread to the rest of Europe. That war was expected to be over by Christmas but it dragged on for more than four years. At the time it was known as the Great War. We know it now as World War I.

Going over the top

The order to climb out of the relative safety of the trench and advance—assaulted by gunfire and weighed down by weapons and heavy equipment—across the mud of no-man's-land toward the enemy was often met with terror.

